Downscript

Installation guide for macOS · version 0.1.0

Downscript is a Chrome extension that collects the videos of a TikTok profile (and Instagram, Facebook and YouTube pages) and turns each one into a Markdown transcript. Everything runs on your own Mac. Installation takes about five minutes and has two parts: the **extension** inside Chrome, and a small local **companion** that runs the transcription tools.

1. Before you start

You need	Notes
A Mac with Google Chrome	Signed in to TikTok in Chrome (the downloader reads its cookies).
Python 3	Check with `python3 --version` in Terminal. If missing, macOS offers to install the developer tools.
Homebrew	Used below to install the tools. Get it at `brew.sh` if you don't have it.
About 600 MB of disk space	For the tools and the Whisper speech model.

2. Install the transcription tools

Open **Terminal** and run:

```
brew install yt-dlp ffmpeg whisper-cpp
```

Then download a Whisper speech model (the "small" model is a good balance of speed and accuracy; English-only users can use `ggml-small.en.bin` instead):

```
mkdir -p ~/Models
curl -L -o ~/Models/ggml-small.bin https://huggingface.co/ggerganov/whisper.cpp/resolv
e/main/ggml-small.bin
```

Find where Homebrew put each tool. You will need these paths in step 5:

```
which yt-dlp ffmpeg whisper-cli
```

> **Apple Silicon Macs (M1 and newer):** Homebrew installs to `/opt/homebrew/bin/`, while Downscript's defaults point to `/usr/local/bin/`. This is expected. Just enter the paths printed by the command above in the settings page (step 5).

3. Unzip and load the extension

1. Unzip **downscript.zip**. Move the resulting `downscript` folder somewhere permanent, for example your Documents folder. **Do not move it afterwards** without re-running the installer in step 4.
2. In Chrome, open `chrome://extensions` and switch on **Developer mode** (top right).
3. Click **Load unpacked** and select the `downscript/extension` folder.
4. Confirm that the extension's ID is `hkmbgalpmjbphbjbldhghodghfmcbafi`. This ID is fixed, so it should match on every machine.
5. Click the puzzle-piece icon in the Chrome toolbar and pin **Downscript** so it is easy to reach.

4. Install the companion

The companion is the small program Chrome talks to. In Terminal, go into the unzipped folder (adjust the path if you placed it elsewhere):

```
cd ~/Documents/downscript/companion
python3 -m venv .venv
.venv/bin/pip install -r requirements.txt
chmod +x install.sh host.py
./install.sh
```

The `.venv` step installs `yt-dlp` together with `curl_cffi`, which TikTok downloads need in order to look like a normal browser. Without it, TikTok answers with "403 Forbidden" errors.

The installer registers the companion with Chrome and prints the folder paths it used. If Chrome showed a different extension ID in step 3, run `./install.sh <the-id>` instead.

5. Check the setup

1. Click the Downscript icon, then the gear icon to open **Settings**.
2. Enter the paths from step 2 for *yt-dlp*, *ffmpeg* and *whisper-cli*, and the path of your model (for example `~/Models/ggml-small.bin`). Choose where transcripts are saved (default: your Downloads folder) and your browser for cookies (default: Chrome). Save.
3. Press **Check setup**. Wait for every row to turn green.

6. Using Downscript

1. In Chrome, open a TikTok profile such as `https://www.tiktok.com/@username` (or an Instagram profile, a Facebook Reels page, or a YouTube playlist).
2. Click the Downscript icon, or press `Cmd + Shift + E`.
3. Press **Start Extraction**. The popup shows discovery and transcription progress.
4. Transcripts are saved as Markdown files, one per video, in:

   ```
   ~/Downloads/<account name>/transcripts/tiktok/transcript_<id>_<title>.md
   ```

5. Running the same profile again skips videos that are already done, and **Cancel** can be resumed later.

> Downloads are paced on purpose. Large profiles take a while, and the extension stops and tells you if a platform starts blocking requests. If that happens, wait a few minutes and run it again.

7. Troubleshooting

Problem	Fix
"Check setup" shows a red row	The path in Settings is wrong. Re-run `which yt-dlp ffmpeg whisper-cli` and paste the exact paths. For the model, check the file exists in `~/Models`.
Chrome cannot reach the companion ("native host not found")	Run `./install.sh` again from the `companion` folder, then reload the extension in `chrome://extensions`. If the extension ID differs from step 3, pass it to the installer.
You moved the `downscript` folder	The installer remembers the folder's location. Run `./install.sh` again from the new location.
Downloads fail with 403 on TikTok	Make sure step 4 was completed (`.venv` with `curl_cffi`) and that you are signed in to TikTok in Chrome. A short wait often helps, because the block is temporary.
Permission errors reading browser cookies	Open System Settings > Privacy & Security > Full Disk Access and allow your Terminal app and Google Chrome, then try again.
"Permission denied" when running a script	Run `chmod +x install.sh host.py` in the `companion` folder.

8. Updating and removing

- **Update:** replace the `downscript` folder with the new version, rebuild the `.venv` (step 4), run `./install.sh`, and click Reload on the extension in `chrome://extensions`.
- **Remove:** click *Remove* on the extension in `chrome://extensions`, delete the `downscript` folder, and delete the file `~/Library/Application Support/Google/Chrome/NativeMessagingHosts/com.downscript.companion.json`.
